

# This text, known in Sanskrit as the Āryaratnolkā-nāma-dhāraṇī-mahāyāna-sūtra and

Toh 847 · Derge Kangyur

This text, known in Sanskrit as the Āryaratnolkā-nāma-dhāraṇī-mahāyāna-sūtra and in Tibetan as the 'Phags pa dkon mchog ta la la'i gzungs zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, bears the English title "The Noble Dhāraṇī Called 'The Jewel Torch.'" It is a Mahāyāna sūtra centered on a dhāraṇī, opening with a dialogue in which the Blessed One directs Mañjuśrī to request the teaching from the bodhisattva Samantabhadra, who is praised as one abiding in the perfection of wisdom and possessed of countless absorptions; the text thus unfolds as an exchange exploring the boundless and inconceivable nature of bodhisattva teachings and the power of this particular dhāraṇī. As a dhāraṇī-sūtra, it belongs to the broader class of Mahāyāna scriptures that combine narrative teaching with protective or mnemonic incantations. This work is catalogued as Toh 847 in the Kangyur, and the colophon fragment preceding its title indicates it formed part of a larger cycle of tantric or sūtric material, here marking the completion of a third continuity (rgyud) before the sūtra's own title is given.

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The Blessed One spoke: "Noble son, I do not cast aside the realm of sentient beings. Noble son, nevertheless the teaching of the bodhisattvas is a teaching that is measureless, and a teaching that is inconceivable."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the dhāraṇī called 'The Jewel Palm.'"

The Blessed One spoke: "Noble son, ask this of the bodhisattva Samantabhadra, and he will teach it to you. Why is this? Noble son, this sublime being abides in the accumulation of wisdom."

Mañjuśrī said: "If the Tathāgata so intends regarding me, I shall ask this sublime being."

The Blessed One spoke: "Mañjuśrī, since you have attained as many absorptions (samādhis) as there are atoms of the finest particles, what need have you to petition the Tathāgata? Noble son, you are endowed with the fortune for all the qualities of a buddha."

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, let it be understood that all those qualities of a buddha which I have relied upon, cultivated in meditation, and practiced extensively, are all through the power of the Tathāgata's person."

The Blessed One spoke: "Noble son, excellent, excellent! You have spoken these words well. Nevertheless, Mañjuśrī, I request of you: ask the bodhisattva Samantabhadra."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this bodhisattva Samantabhadra teaches what is extremely profound; he has realized and fully comprehended the Great Vehicle."

The Blessed One spoke: "Noble son, you too are the sovereign king of all phenomena, so do not say this to me. Moreover, noble son, you possess an inconceivable absorption that abides in emptiness."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, joined his ten fingers in añjali and, having paid homage to the bodhisattva Samantabhadra, spoke these words to him: "O child of the Victor, if you grant me the occasion, I will ask you a word of a few syllables."

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "Noble son, if you know this to be the proper time, then ask."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, spoke these words to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Samantabhadra: "O child of the Victor, what is the meaning of the ground of what is called 'buddha, buddha'?"

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "O child of the Victor, the meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of groundlessness. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of the absence of any entity. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of the inconceivable. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of the unequaled that is equal. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of freedom from conceptual elaboration. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of non-elaboration. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of nothing to be taken up. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of nothing to be abandoned. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of being equal to space. The meaning of the ground of buddhahood is the meaning of being beyond expression. Noble son, such is the intrinsic nature of the qualities of a buddha."

Mañjuśrī said: "O child of the Victor, if all phenomena are free of conceptual elaboration, then how is it taught that the qualities of a buddha are known?"

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "O child of the Victor, this teaching is itself something that cannot be taught."

Mañjuśrī said:

"O child of the Victor, if it cannot be taught, then what is being taught?"

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "What cannot be taught is taught by means of designation."

Mañjuśrī said: "O child of the Victor, by means of designation, what is being designated?"

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "Mañjuśrī, by means of designation, neither an entity nor the absence of an entity is designated."

Mañjuśrī said: "O child of the Victor, if by means of designation neither an entity nor the absence of an entity is designated, then how are the three vehicles taught?"

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "Mañjuśrī, do not become attached to the dharmadhātu, which is free of attachment. Why is this? Mañjuśrī, it is because the Tathāgata has taught that all phenomena are without entity. And as for why they are without entity, it is because the five aggregates are without any basis for apprehension."

Mañjuśrī said: "Is awakening accompanied by conceptual elaboration, or is it free of conceptual elaboration?"

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "Noble son, awakening is neither accompanied by conceptual elaboration nor free of conceptual elaboration. For awakening, that which is accompanied by conceptual elaboration, and that which is free of conceptual elaboration — these are not two; they are indivisible as two."

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Samantabhadra, saying: "Noble son, excellent, excellent is this inconceivable teaching you have given." When these words were spoken, this world together with its gods became bewildered.

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, a teaching of the Dharma such as this is not one that ought to be sought by ordinary means."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, it is just so; it is as you have said."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, is it by this very designation that all phenomena are designated?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, it is just so; it is as you have said."

Then the bodhisattva Samantabhadra said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this door of complete purity is difficult to have faith in."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, it is just so; it is as you have said."

Then the bodhisattva Sāgaramati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this door of complete purity taught by the bodhisattva Samantabhadra has been well spoken."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, it is just so; it is as you have said. Noble son, furthermore, this is concordant with all phenomena. This is the great rain of the Dharma."

Then the brahmin who was like a great sāla tree, abiding in equality, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, awakening is the inconceivable equality, in which no syllable is apprehended and no word is apprehended."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, it is just so. In the dharmadhātu no word appears, and no meaning appears either."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is concordant with emptiness? What is its aspect? What is its sign? What is its characteristic?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, emptiness is inexpressible and indescribable. Whatever faith there is in this inexpressible nature of reality — that is called emptiness. This emptiness is without letters; therefore it is called emptiness. This emptiness is indescribable; therefore it is called emptiness."

Then the bodhisattva Samantabhadra said this to the bodhisattva Dharmamati: "Child of noble family, you have spoken well in explaining the dhāraṇī called the Rare and Supreme Jewel. Child of noble family, the qualities of a buddha are inconceivable. If even those sentient beings who merely hear the name of this category of teaching thereby draw close to omniscience itself, then what need is there to mention those who hold this category of teaching, recite it, master it completely, and accomplish it in accordance with suchness? Such beings will certainly become buddhas."

Dharmamati said: "Kye, child of the Victor, it is indeed so. It is just as you have said. One should understand that those endowed with profound wisdom have

been empowered by the Tathāgata."

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "If even those excellent persons into whose ears such teachings as these have merely resounded are to be understood as having received prophecy regarding the qualities of a buddha, then what need is there to mention those who have gained this category of teaching in hand?"

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One and said this: "Blessed One, please observe — because I have not known such teachings as these, I am like one born blind. Blessed One, it is not only I alone who have become like one born blind; Blessed One, all those sentient beings who have not heard this category of teaching have likewise become like ones born blind."

The Blessed One declared: "Elder, it is just so. It is just as you have said."

Śāradvatīputra said: "Blessed One, please explain that very inconceivability."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāradvatīputra, go and urge Śakra (Indra), Brahmā, and all the guardians of the world. Proclaim also the command of the Tathāgata. Proclaim to that assembly this dhāraṇī as well, called the Supreme Dharma Seal, the Rare and Supreme Jewel."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra, having heard the command of the Tathāgata, for the sake of the meaning of this dhāraṇī of the Rare and Supreme Jewel, with his throat utterly parched, spoke of this matter to Śakra, Brahmā, and those guardians of the world, saying: "Gather together, all you who listen to the Dharma. The Tathāgata is about to explain the dhāraṇī of the Rare and Supreme Jewel and will also teach its very inconceivability — so gather together! You will surely come to regret it later. Kye, friends, it is extremely difficult to find such a precious sūtra as this arising in the world."

Then, in that very instant, Śakra, Brahmā, and all the guardians of the world gathered together, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and having taken their seats before the Blessed One, joined their palms and made this request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the dhāraṇī of the Rare and Supreme Jewel."

Then the Blessed One, remaining silent, thereby granted his consent. Although Śakra, Brahmā, and all the guardians of the world made their request two times and three times, the Blessed One remained silent.

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the dhāraṇī called the Rare and Supreme Jewel. Sugata, please explain it."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One put forth from his mouth the organ of his tongue.

Mañjuśrī, these are the faults of those deluded people. Mañjuśrī, in brief, at the time of their death, from each and every pore of their body innumerable sufferings of the hell-beings will arise. Even if they are born as humans, they will always become blind, and they will become without a tongue. Mañjuśrī, furthermore, those who abandon this discourse on Dharma will, in this very life, become leprous in body; their lips will appear fearsome and frightful; their bodies will become wasted; their bodies will become naked; their bodies will become withered; they will become like hungry ghosts (pretas).

Mañjuśrī, furthermore, as for the places where those deluded people will be born, I know this through the inconceivable wisdom of a buddha.

Mañjuśrī the Youthful said: "May the Blessed One grant a prophecy. May the Sugata grant a prophecy."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, be silent, do not ask such a thing. If this were spoken, the world together with its gods would become agitated, would become terrified, would become dismayed, would become utterly dismayed."

Mañjuśrī said: "So that these beings, having heard such a thing, will never again abandon the sublime Dharma, out of compassionate intent may the Blessed One please explain it."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, beneath the earth there exist hells for sentient beings, named as follows: Hot, Extremely Hot, Black Line, Ablaze All Around, Utterly Ablaze, Hard to Touch, Fierce, Sharp-Beaked, Iron Mortar, Iron Pestle, Pit of Darkness, Head-Upraised, Humped, Monkey-Faced, Ever Ablaze, Putrid, Ever Foul-Smelling, Utterly Destroying, Certainly Destroying, and Extremely Harmfully Destroying. Mañjuśrī, these are the hells into which those deluded people will be born."

Then the bodhisattva Samantabhadra addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, where will those who proclaim the Dharma be born after they pass away and transmigrate from this life?"

The Blessed One declared: "Samantabhadra, well have you asked this question. Samantabhadra, a son or daughter of noble family who proclaims

the Dharma will, after passing away and transmigrating from this life, be born in a buddha-field, a world-system adorned by the Tathāgata of inconceivable confidence, utterly magnificent — in that world-system there are none but bodhisattvas, entirely beautiful. At the time of death, that son of noble family will behold one hundred twenty million buddhas face to face. Son of noble family, in brief, the benefits for that son of noble family are innumerable and immeasurable; even in a thousand eons they could not be fully expressed."

The bodhisattva Samantabhadra said: "Blessed One, in the final age, in the final time, what kind of beings will arise who will abandon this discourse on Dharma?"

The Blessed One declared: "Samantabhadra, the beings who will abandon such teachings as these will for the most part be those who have gone forth, saying: 'These are mere poetic compositions; these were not spoken by the Tathāgata; these were fabricated by their own authors; these sūtras were never heard of before' — grumbling thus, they will abandon this discourse on Dharma. And having abandoned it, they will not confess it and will not make amends."

Those sentient beings will become like a stūpa worthy of worship for the world together with its gods, māras, and Brahmās. They cannot be harmed by māras, nor by the gods of the class of māras, nor by renunciants, nor by those who dwell in the household life, nor likewise by kings, nor by great ministers, nor by householders — so saying, they raised a great clamor of acclaim.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, it is difficult to find such a precious sūtra arising in the world. Yet through the power of the Tathāgata such a Dharma has arisen in the world, and through that very power of the Tathāgata these sentient beings as well have heard it.

Then the Blessed One, extending the organ of his tongue, said to the venerable Ānanda: Ānanda, hold this discourse of Dharma! Retain it! Recite it! Master it completely!

Then the venerable Ānanda circumambulated the Blessed One three times and said this: Blessed One, I have held this discourse of Dharma, and henceforth I shall not let it slip from memory.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, that entire assembly of bodhisattvas, together with the noble bodhisattva Samantabhadra, Mañjuśrī the Youthful, the venerable Śāradvatīputra, the other great śrāvakas, and the world

together with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, all rejoiced and highly praised what the Blessed One had spoken.

The noble discourse of Dharma called the Dhāraṇī of the Precious Tālala is complete.

Translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Surendrabodhi and the chief editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé.

## Translator's Notes

- The passage ends mid-sentence with "Mañjuśrī said:" as the Tibetan source text itself breaks off at this point; this is not an omission in translation but reflects the given excerpt's boundary.
- "Dkon mchog ta la la" is rendered as "the Rare and Supreme Jewel," treating "ta la la" as an exclamatory/rare quality attached to "dkon mchog" (rare and supreme/jewel); the exact Sanskrit reconstruction of this dhāraṇī's name is uncertain and may simply be a transliterated proper name rather than a translatable phrase — this has been rendered descriptively per context.
- The list of hell names includes some whose Sanskrit equivalents are uncertain (e.g., "Humped," "Monkey-Faced," "Head-Upraised") as these do not correspond to the standard canonical lists of major/minor hells; they have been rendered descriptively based on the literal Tibetan.
- The title "Dhāraṇī of the Precious Tālala" (Tib. dkon mchog ta la la'i gzungs) preserves an obscure element, "ta la la," whose precise Sanskrit referent is uncertain; it has been left transliterated rather than guessed at. The phrase "ca co dang ga zha'i sgra" (rendered "a great clamor of acclaim") denotes an onomatopoeic expression of a joyous uproar and has no precise single-word English equivalent.

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## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.